

# The anchor tenant returns

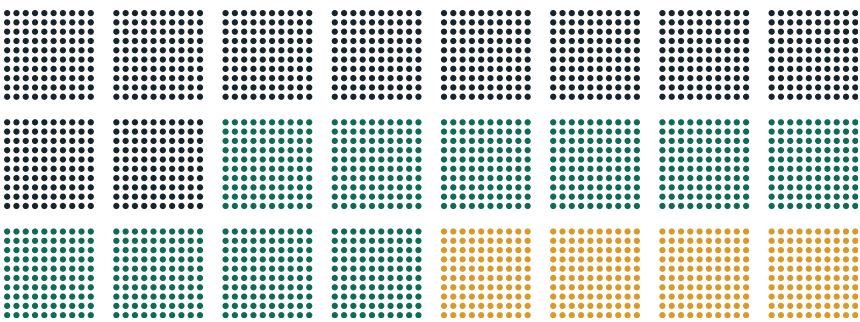
**Signal** Meta signed 20-year contracts for 3,760 MW of nuclear output from four plants already running in Illinois, Ohio and Pennsylvania. About 12% of that is new output. The rest was already on the grid.

**Read** Long power contracts are old. New: a tech company reserving city-sized supply that already exists, inside a market that is short, where households share the cost of the shortage.

Researched October 1, 2026. Tags in the left margin: Fact is sourced, Read is our inference, Est is computed.

## How big is 3,760 MW?

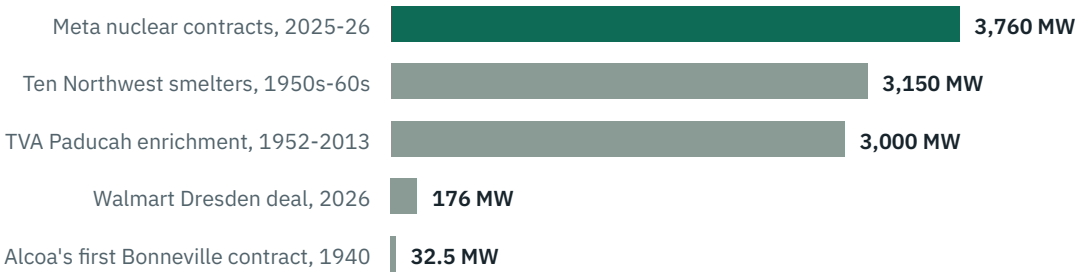
Each dot is 1,160 homes. Each block of 100 dots is one tenth of Chicago's households. Twenty-four blocks is roughly the electricity Meta reserved.



# 2.4

times every household in Chicago, powered for a year. Estimate: 3,760 MW at 90% of hours, 10,791 kWh per home, 1.16 million Chicago households. Math on page 3.

## Against the last industry that anchored a grid



*"In 1940 Alcoa signed for Bonneville dam power. Ten Northwest smelters ran on it for sixty years, then sold the power back and left. The dams stayed. The buyers didn't."*

Northwest Power and Conservation Council history.

## How 2.4 Chicagos was computed

|                      |                      |               |                      |                     |                |
|----------------------|----------------------|---------------|----------------------|---------------------|----------------|
| 3,760 MW             | x 90% x 8,760 h      | = 29.6 bn kWh | / 10,791 kWh         | = 2.75 M homes      | = 2.4 Chicagos |
| Meta contracted:     | hours running, hours | a year        | average US home, EIA | / 1,160,205 Chicago | estimate       |
| 1,121 + 30 + 2,176 + | in a year            |               | 2022                 | households, Census  |                |
| 433                  |                      |               |                      | 2020-24             |                |

## Who else is doing this

| Buyer     | What they bought                                                                         | Size        | Term      | New to the grid | The read                                                    |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|-----------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Meta      | Clinton (IL) plus three Vistra plants (OH, PA)                                           | 3,760 MW    | 20 yr     | 12%             | Largest block. Mostly existing output                       |
| Amazon    | Susquehanna (PA), moved to a grid contract after regulators rejected the on-site version | 1,920 MW    | to 2042   | 0%              | \$18 billion for power that already flowed                  |
| Amazon    | Calvert Cliffs (MD), signed Sep 30                                                       | 690 MW      | 20 yr     | 28%             | Filed a campus, withdrew it, kept the power. Sequence below |
| Microsoft | Crane, the former Three Mile Island unit, restart                                        | 835 MW      | 20 yr     | 100%            | The one restart a buyer clearly caused                      |
| Google    | Duane Arnold (IA) restart, plus uprates at two Georgia plants                            | 615 + 96 MW | 25 yr     | 100%            | Longest term in the book                                    |
| Data4     | Output from EDF, the French state utility that runs the national nuclear fleet           | 40 MW       | 12 yr     | 0%              | How it looks where the state owns the plants                |
| Walmart   | Dresden (IL), for a perishable distribution center opening 2029                          | 176 MW      | 2 x 15 yr | 17%             | First retailer. The template for any big automated site     |

Across the signed book: 8,006 MW, 27% new. The two biggest blocks are 100% existing output. No deal has disclosed a price.

## What 24/7 power looks like if you're not a hyperscaler

|                       |                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Utility bill          | Month to month. Price taker. No reserved capacity. Where most companies still are.                                                                                  |
| Clean-energy contract | 10 to 15 years. A price hedge and a sustainability claim. No reliability benefit, no electrons to your site. Walmart's 2024 Texas solar deal.                       |
| Site-tied firm supply | 15 to 25 years. Capacity plus energy, tied to a named plant. Minimum bills, collateral, curtailment clauses. Walmart's 2026 nuclear deal. Where the line forms now. |

### 25 MW

where utility minimum-bill rules start in Ohio and Virginia

### 85%

of reserved power billed, used or not, for 12 to 14 years

### 4 years

typical ramp before the full minimum applies

### 30 minutes

to cut off on command in Texas, the price of a fast hookup

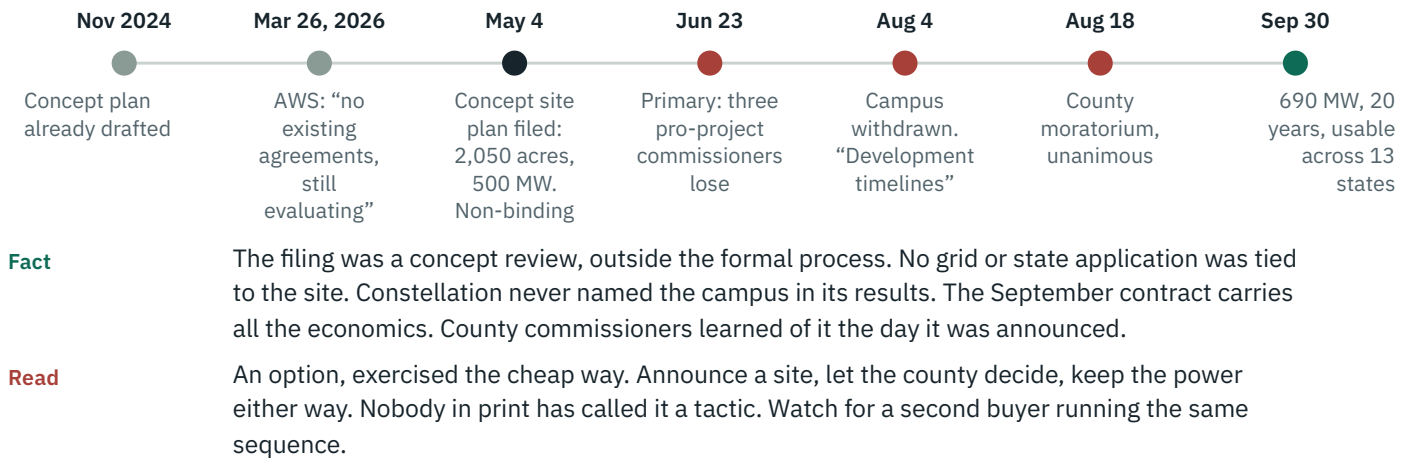
An automated warehouse, a cold-chain hub, a battery plant and a fab all cross 25 MW. The utility prices the power line before the automation plan does.

## What each side leaves out

| Side                       | Claim                                                                                          | Omission                                                                                       | What settles it                                                       |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Market monitor             | "38.2% (\$6.3 billion) of 2028/29 capacity charges" go to data centers                         | Counts capacity charges only. Rutgers finds a retail effect of \$0.90 a month, not significant | Which loads states bill for PJM's \$555 backstop (filing ER26-3380)   |
| Data center industry study | "No quantitative evidence" of a historical subsidy; load growth is about 50% of the price jump | The market monitor assigns 63% of the same jump, \$9.3 billion, to data centers                | A 2025/26 auction re-run with data center load removed                |
| Power seller               | Power "will continue to go to the grid for all electricity users"                              | 3,297 of Meta's 3,760 MW is existing output. No price is disclosed                             | Contract prices, plus what Vistra would have retired without the deal |

## The site was the option

Amazon at Calvert Cliffs, concept plan to power contract. The power flows into PJM, the grid operator for 13 states and Washington DC, so a Maryland contract serves Amazon anywhere in that footprint.



## The last time an industry anchored a grid

**Fact** Alcoa signed for 32.5 average MW of Bonneville dam power in 1940. By the 1950s ten smelters drew 3,150 average MW and made 40% of US aluminum. When prices spiked in 2000-01, Kaiser made about \$130 million reselling its contract power instead of making metal. Industrial load fell 90% by 2006. The last smelter closed in 2023.

**Read** Anchors renegotiate at every contract boundary and leave when the spread flips. Bonneville's other customers absorbed the power. In today's private markets nobody absorbs it automatically, which is why the minimum-bill rules exist.

## Who gains, who carries

### Gains

Meta: 20 years of dedicated supply, and an exemption from curtailment.

Plant owners: revenue certainty to relicense and uprate.

Host towns: plants stay open, jobs and taxes continue.

### Carries

Households in the 13-state grid: data centers are 38.2% of 2028/29 capacity charges, \$6.3 billion.

Virginia homes: \$13.60 a month across 2026-27.

### The caveat

National bill studies through 2024 find small or no effect. Each one says slack supply kept it small.

PJM no longer has slack.

## For an executive

- Which of our sites cross 25 MW in the next five years?
- If automation ramps two years late, what do we owe on power reserved and unused?
- When we buy a facility, does its power contract transfer with it?

## What to watch

- Nov 3, 2026** 34 ballot measures. Most restrict: confirms the read. Most fail: breaks it.
- Nov 16, 2026** FERC filings. Firm contract-demand rules confirm. Softer rules break it.
- Dec 2, 2026** Backstop auction. Near \$555 per MW-day confirms. Well below breaks it.
- Next campus** Another buyer drops a site, keeps the power: confirms. None in a year: breaks.

Researched by NodeJ Deep Research. Every figure traces to a companion report with a source link on each number. For the full report, or a brief on a signal in your industry: [julian@nodej.ai](mailto:julian@nodej.ai)